

# THE RAINMAKER

**GAUTAM ADANI IS UNSTOPPABLE. THE ADANI GROUP COMPANIES ARE BLAZING AWAY AT THE BOURSES, AND HALF A DOZEN NEW VENTURES ARE READY TO UNLOCK VALUE IN THE NEAR FUTURE, PROMISING HEFTY RETURNS TO SHAREHOLDERS AND INVESTORS**

**BY ANAND ADHIKARI**

**S**IXTY-YEAR-OLD Gautam Shantilal Adani, popularly called Gautambhai, gets energised by writings on 'resilience'. This Gujarati entrepreneur recently stumbled upon a write-up by Martin Seligman, dubbed the 'father of positive psychology'. In the write-up, the American psychologist narrated that he mastered the power of optimism "the long, hard way, through many years of research on failure". He discovered that resilient people have the stomach to see failures as transitory. Adani, a college dropout, also believes that failure isn't fatal. "I am an incurable optimist," he often says to people close to him. His perseverance and determination to succeed have made him what he is today—the world's third-richest person.

In the 1980s, when fellow Gujarati Dhirubhai Ambani, the founder of Reliance Industries Ltd (RIL), was displacing the oldest and wealthiest business families from their perches, Adani landed in Mumbai to try his hand

at diamond trading. He soon founded and listed his first commodity trading firm, Adani Exports. In 2002, when Mukesh Ambani was elevated as RIL Chairman after Dhirubhai Ambani's death, Adani Exports was a relatively inconsequential player, with Reliance's market cap 73 times higher. Today, companies of the Adani Group have cobbled up a valuation of ₹19.31 lakh crore, as of November 18, surpassing that of RIL by ₹1.84 lakh crore. In terms of average annual market cap between October 2021 and September 2022 (the BT500 study period) though, RIL pips the Adani Group to the top spot; RIL's market cap is ₹17 lakh crore, while the Adani Group's is ₹13.72 lakh crore. The battle for market cap supremacy may still continue, as RIL has a few diamonds in its wardrobe. But then, so has Gautambhai.

The high growth potential of his listed entities is reflected in the BT500 ranking (see box 'A Story in Numbers'). The Adani Group's current market cap is already higher than the GDP of countries like Ukraine and Sri